

Predicative vs. attributive stative passives

Evidence from Voice

Mariam Asatryan and Eva Neu

SinFonIJA 19 | September 30, 2026

University of Massachusetts Amherst

Stative passives describe a state resulting from an event (1a). They are semantically distinct from both eventive passives (1b) and adjectives (1c).

- | | | | |
|-----|----|----------------------|-------------------------|
| (1) | a. | The door is opened. | <i>Stative passive</i> |
| | b. | The door was opened. | <i>Eventive passive</i> |
| | c. | The door is open. | <i>Adjective</i> |

Note that not all stative ‘passives’ are in fact passives in the sense of containing an existentially closed external argument.

Stative passives can surface in both predicative and attributive position (2):

- | | | | |
|-----|----|---------------------|--------------------|
| (2) | a. | The door is opened. | <i>Predicative</i> |
| | b. | the opened door | <i>Attributive</i> |

Recent work has shown that in English, stative passives in attributive position can receive an eventive interpretation.

(Biggs and Embick, 2025; see also Sleeman, 2011)

We look at stative passives (so-called resultatives) in Standard Eastern Armenian (SEA), which bear a distinct morphological marker, *-ats*. We make two empirical findings:

- Only attributive resultatives can receive an eventive interpretation, as in English;
- Only attributive resultatives can contain active Voice.

Our solution: attributive resultatives in SEA are reduced relative clauses which can embed an eventive verbal domain with an active Voice head.

The new puzzle: if attributive resultatives are reduced relative clauses, why are they marked with the same morpheme as predicative stative passives?

Our solution: both reduced relative clauses and predicative stative passives are adjectival in nature.

- Introduction
- Background
- Data
- Analysis
- Discussion

Background I: Voice morphology

SEA has a morpheme *-v* (NACT) that forms either passives or anticausatives depending on the verb (3):

- (3) a. Trichq-ə tʃ^hexark-**v**-el e Aram-i
flight-DEF cancel-NACT-PERF be.NPST.3SG Aram-GEN
koxmi-ts^h.
side-ABL
'The flight has been canceled by Aram.' *Passivizing*
- b. Bajak-ə jard-**v**-el e (*Aram-i
glass-DEF break-NACT-PERF be.NPST.3SG (*Aram-GEN
koxm-its^h).
side-ABL
'The glass broke (*by Aram).' *Anticausativizing*

Background I: Voice morphology

Both passivizing and anticausativizing verbs are unmarked in their active transitive form (4):

- (4) a. Aram-ə tʃ^hexark-el e trits^hq-ə.
Aram-DEF cancel-PERF be.NPST.3SG flight-DEF
'Aram has canceled the flight.' *Passivizing*
- b. Aram-ə jard-el e bajak-ə.
Aram-DEF break-PERF be.NPST.3SG glass-DEF
'Aram has broken the glass.' *Anticausativizing*

(Megerdooonian, 2002)

Background I: Voice morphology

We assume the following analysis:

- With passivizing verbs, *-v* spells out passive Voice;
- With anticausativizing verbs, *-v* spells out expletive Voice;
- Active Voice is phonologically null.

We will refer to verbs with *-v* as marked and verbs without *-v* as unmarked.

(see Schäfer, 2008)

Background II: Resultatives

Both passivizing and anticausativizing verbs form what are known in the Armenian literature as resultatives with the suffix *-ats*. Here, we show marked resultatives (with *-v*) (5):

- (5) a. Trichq-ə tʃ^hexark-**v-ats** e (Aram-i
flight-DEF cancel-**NACT-RES** be.NPST.3SG (Aram-GEN
koxm-its^h).
side-ABL)
'The flight is canceled (by Aram).' *Passivizing*
- b. Bajak-ə jard-**v-ats** e (*Aram-i koxm-ts^h).
glass-DEF break-**NACT-RES** be.NPST.3SG (Aram-GEN side-ABL)
'The glass is broken (*by Aram).' *Anticausativizing*

Background II: Resultatives

Resultatives can also be used attributively (6):

(6) a. tʃ^hexark-**v-ats** trichq
cancel-**NACT-RES** flight
'a canceled flight'

Passivizing

b. jard-**v-ats** bajak
break-**NACT-RES** glass
'a broken glass'

Anticausativizing

To summarize, we will be concerned with two morphemes:

- The nonactive morpheme *-v*, which forms either anticausatives or passives depending on the verb class;
- The morpheme *-ats*, which forms resultatives.

- Introduction
- Background
- Data
- Analysis
- Discussion

The first contrast between predicative and attributive resultatives: only attributive resultatives can receive an eventive interpretation.

Predicative resultatives can only receive a stative interpretation: the state resulting from the event must hold at the time of evaluation (7).

- (7) a. Trichq-ə tʃ^hexark-v-ats e.
flight-DEF cancel-NACT-RES be.NPST.3SG
'The flight is canceled.'
- b. Bajak-ə jard-v-ats e.
glass-DEF break-NACT-RES be.NPST.3SG
'The glass is broken.'

Accordingly, eventive modifiers like temporal and manner adverbs are unavailable (8):

- (8) a. (*Yerek) trichq-ə tʃ^hexark-v-ats e.
yesterday flight-DEF cancel-NACT-RES be.NPST.3SG
'The flight is canceled (*yesterday).'
- b. (*Yerek) bajak-ə jard-v-ats e.
yesterday glass-DEF break-NACT-RES be.NPST.3SG
'The glass is broken (*yesterday).'

By contrast, attributive resultatives are compatible with eventive modification, and the result state does not need to hold at the time of evaluation (9):

- (9) a. Yerek tʃ^hexark-v-ats trichq-ə (irakanac-v-el
yesterday cancel-NACT-RES flight-DEF (operate-NACT-PERF
e aysor).
be.NPST.3SG today)
'The flight that has been canceled yesterday (operated today).'
- b. Yerek jard-v-ats bajak-ə (norog-v-el
yesterday break-NACT-RES glass-DEF (repair-NACT-PERF
e aysor).
be.NPST.3SG today)
'The glass that has broken yesterday (has been repaired today).'

As in English, SEA resultatives can receive an eventive interpretation only in attributive position. This contrast holds for both verb classes and for both marked and unmarked resultatives.

The second contrast between predicative and attributive resultatives: only attributive resultatives can contain active Voice.

Remember that marked resultatives (bearing *-v*) are anticausative with anticausativizing verbs, and passive with passivizing verbs.

Remember also that in their unmarked form, both passivizing and anticausativizing verbs are active transitives. What happens when we form unmarked resultatives (only *-ats*, no *-v*)?

	Predicative	Attributive
Passivizing verbs	∅	Active transitive
Anticausativizing verbs	Anticausative	Active transitive

With passivizing verbs, unmarked predicative resultatives are ungrammatical (10):

- (10) *Trichq-ə tʃ^hexark-ats e.
flight-DEF cancel-RES be.NPST.3SG
Intended: 'The flight is canceled.'

This indicates that predicative resultatives cannot contain active Voice.

With anticausativizing verbs, unmarked predicative resultatives are anticausatives (11):

- (11) Bajakə jard-ats e (*Aram-i koxm-its^h).
glass break-RES be.NPST.3SG Aram-GEN side-ABL
'The glass is broken (*by Aram).'

The interpretation is identical to the marked variant.

- Like passivizing verbs, anticausativizing verbs are active transitives when unmarked.
- We have argued that predicative resultatives are not compatible with active transitives.
- Unlike passivizing verbs, anticausativizing verbs are not ungrammatical as unmarked resultatives. But crucially, they are also not interpreted as active transitives.

The bottom line: predicative resultatives cannot contain active Voice.

To recap, in their unmarked form, both passivizing and anticausativizing verbs are active transitives. In predicative position, this was blocked. But in attributive position, this is the interpretation we get:

	Predicative	Attributive
Passivizing verbs	∅	Active transitive
Anticausativizing verbs	Anticausative	Active transitive

With both verb classes, attributive unmarked resultatives receive an active transitive interpretation and allow for an overt genitive-marked agent:

- (12) a. (Aram-i) tʃ^hexark-ats trichqə...
(Aram-GEN) cancel-RES flight...
'The flight that Aram has canceled...'
Lit: 'Aram's canceled flight...'
- b. (Aram-i) jard-ats bajakə...
(Aram-GEN) break-RES glass...
'The glass that Aram has broken...'
Lit: 'Aram's broken glass...'

The active transitive interpretation that we would expect for unmarked forms, but which was blocked in predicative position, is available in attributive position.

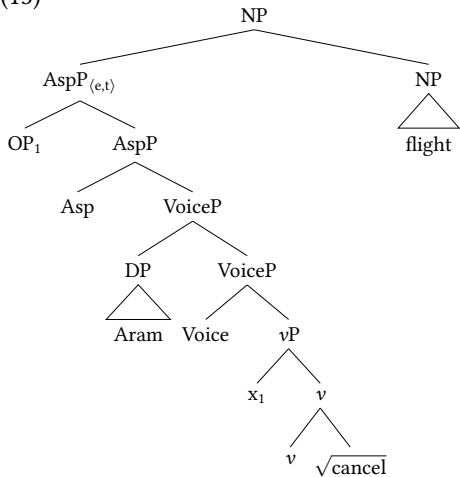
Attributive and predicative resultatives differ in two respects:

- Event semantics: only attributive resultatives can receive an eventive interpretation;
- Voice: only attributive resultatives can contain an active Voice head introducing an overt or *pro* external argument.

- Introduction
- Background
- Data
- Analysis
- Discussion

We propose that attributive resultatives are reduced relative clauses which can embed an eventive verbal domain with an active Voice head.

(13)



The truth conditions of an attributive resultative with active Voice are shown in a simplified form in (14):

$$(14) \quad \llbracket \text{Arami } t_j^h \text{ exarkats trichq} \rrbracket = \lambda x. \text{flight}(x) \wedge \exists e. [\text{cancel}(e) \wedge \text{Theme}(e, x) \wedge \text{Agent}(e, \text{Aram})]$$

Asp can also embed any other kind of verbal domain, such as an anticausative, an eventive passive or a stative passive.

- Introduction
- Background
- Data
- Analysis
- Discussion

The new puzzle: if attributive resultatives are reduced relative clauses, why are they marked with the same morpheme as predicative stative passives?

If this syncretism is limited to SEA, it might be a case of accidental homophony, but not if it replicates cross-linguistically.

We propose that what reduced relative clauses and stative passives share is that they are adjectival in nature:

- Reduced relative clauses surface in attributive position and modify nouns, like adjectives;
- Stative passives denote states, like adjectives.

More formally, both reduced relative clauses and stative passives might be deverbal forms of type $\langle e, t \rangle$:

- Reduced relative clauses must be of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ to combine with the NP via Predicate Modification.
- Stative passives would be of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ if all eventuality variables are closed before the entity argument is introduced.

This suggests a particular analysis of stative passives – see Appendix A, and ask me in the Q&A!

Questions for further research:

- What does the resultative morpheme *-ats* spell out?
- Does our analysis of SEA resultatives extend to English? (Appendix B)
- What happens when a second auxiliary is added to a predicative resultative? (Appendix C)

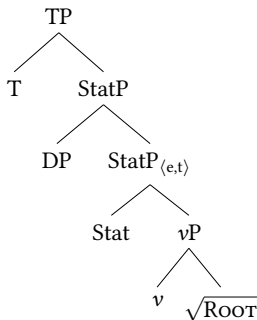
References

- Biggs, A., & Embick, D. (2025). English (stative) passive participles: Category, argument introduction, and interpretation [Ms., McMaster University/University of Pennsylvania].
- Embick, D. (2023). Smaller syntax for English stative passives: A first report. *Acta Linguistica Academica*, 70, 285–316.
- Megerdooonian, K. (2002). Beyond words and phrases: A unified theory of predicate composition [Doctoral dissertation, University of Southern California].
- Paparounas, L. (2025). Greek stative passives as small non-passives [Ms., Université du Québec à Montréal].
- Schäfer, F. (2008). The syntax of (anti-)causatives. John Benjamins.
- Sleeman, P. (2011). Verbal and adjectival participles: Position and internal structure. *Lingua*, 121, 1569–1587.
- Wood, J., & Marantz, A. (2017). The interpretation of external arguments. In R. D'Alessandro, I. Franco, & Á. J. Gallego (Eds.), *The verbal domain* (pp. 255–278). Oxford UP.

Appendix A: Stative syntax

Stative passives would be of type $\langle e, t \rangle$ if the DP is merged high, in SpecStatP, and StatP does not further merge with Asp (15):

(15)



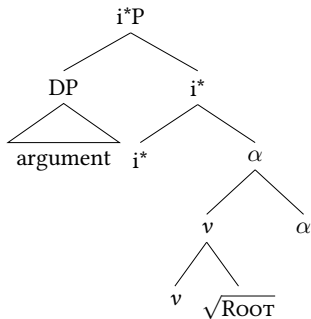
(see also Embick, 2023; Paparounas, 2025)

Biggs and Embick (2025) posit two functional heads in their analysis of stative passives:

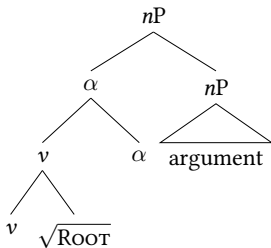
- i^* : introduces arguments
- α : determines a non-verbal distribution; interpreted as a state when in the complement of i^* , semantically vacuous otherwise

(see Wood and Marantz, 2017)

(16) Predicative stative passive



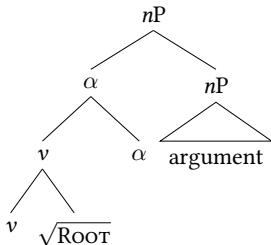
- (17) Attributive 'stative passive' with eventive interpretation



Here, α is semantically vacuous, and the argument is introduced not by i^* but by v .

Appendix B: Previous work

(18) Attributive 'stative passive' with eventive interpretation



We see the following problems:

- The nP is not of the right type to saturate the argument position of v : it is of type $\langle e, t \rangle$, not e .
- Nothing ever closes the eventuality variable introduced by v , resulting in another type mismatch.

Appendix C: Predicative resultatives with two auxiliaries

Predicative resultatives can also surface in a complex structure, with an aspect-bearing auxiliary in addition to the tense-bearing copula (19):

- (19) a. Aram-ə trichq-ə tʃ^hexark-ats e ex-el.
Aram-DEF flight-DEF cancel-RES be.NPST.3SG exist-**PERF**
Approximately: 'Aram had the flight canceled.'
Means: 'Aram has canceled the flight and the state resulting from that event holds at the topic time.'
- b. Aram-ə bajakə jard-ats e ex-el.
Aram-DEF glass break-RES be.NPST.3SG exist-**PERF**
Approximately: 'Aram had the glass broken.'
Means: 'Aram has broken the glass and the state resulting from that event holds at the topic time.'

The interpretation is stative, but external arguments are licensed.

Appendix C: Predicative resultatives with two auxiliaries

Complex structures are compatible with unmarked resultatives as well as their marked counterparts (20):

- (20) a. Trichq-ə tʃ^hexark-**v**-ats e ex-**el**
flight-DEF cancel-**NACT**-RES be.NPST.3SG exist-**PERF**
(Aram-i koxm-ts^h).
(Aram-GEN side-ABL)
'The flight had been canceled (by Aram).'
- b. Bajakə jard-**v**-ats e ex-**el**.
glass break-**NACT**-RES be.NPST.3SG exist-**PERF**
Approximately: 'The glass had been broken.'
Means: 'The glass was broken.'

Appendix C: Predicative resultatives with two auxiliaries

A summary of the three constructions:

- Predicative resultatives, one auxiliary: no eventive interpretation, no active Voice
- Attributive resultatives: eventive interpretation and active Voice possible
- Predicative resultatives, two auxiliaries: no eventive interpretation, but active Voice possible